

Q How is the i18n/i10n work at OLPC shaping up?

It's in quite good shape—though, as always, we need more people who can help us out :-)

Q There is some eBookReader hardware available in the market (if not in India). Are there features that excite you?

Nook's dual display system sounds interesting—not sure how useful it would be in a real life scenario. Newspapers via e-book-readers is another interesting concept—I often dream of kids using activities to write, edit and publish their own newspaper/school journal, and circulate the final product amongst themselves by sharing (or maybe via the XS school server).

Q You aren't showing this off at events. Don't you have plans along those lines?

I plan on doing a talk at FOSS.in, Bangalore, in December. I'll also speak about the more experimental stuff in my work, as well as a general case study type of thing in a conference called 'Designing for Children' with focus on 'play + learn' at IIT Bombay in February next year.

Q You are known to be a reclusive developer. Tell us a little bit about yourself.

I am from Kolkata (West Bengal, India) where I work from home. I'm a foodie and one of my pastimes is to explore interesting food joints in my city (ranging from the roadside food-vendor to fancy restaurants). I also tend to have fun taking photographs. I have a pet cat who does not have any name (since anyone who has read Elliott's *The Naming Of Cats* is aware that it is only the cat herself who knows her own, real name). I have a habit of playing practical jokes (I was quite notorious in my college for my tricks).

Q I know that Seymour Papert, Alan Kay and a few others have been a great influence on your thoughts

“There have been quite accurate processes for automatic conversion of music/video to digital format, but sadly the same is not true for books.

around the project. How do you conceive the 'design' part of it?

Seymour Papert's work has been significant to me in a personal manner, as it has been instrumental in my journey of trying to make sense out of my own experiences in school (which was quite a roller-coaster ride for me). Alan Kay's concept of the Dynabook has had a more direct impact on at least my work (in a manner of speaking, the entire concept of OLPC and Sugar is centred around the concepts proposed by Kay and Papert).

If you read Kay's 1972 paper *A Personal Computer for Children of All Ages*, the parallel between what is described, and what many in the OLPC and Sugar community visualise today is remarkable. The 'inspirational spark' for many of the ideas that I proposed in my 'Braindump on ebooks' (sayamindu.randomink.org/ramblings/2009/08/12/braindump-on-ebooks/) came after seeing a talk by Dr Kay in one of the meetings organised by OLPC. The concept of programmable 'microworlds', as described by Seymour Papert in his work, has also been a central theme in my ideas.

Q It is being said that e-books are the future and so forth. But with not enough content, do you think that great software like yours can make an impact? How does the relevant content get into shape?

This is an interesting question, in the sense that the transition from books to e-books involves the largest amount of 'legacy content' till date. Stored music, movies, etc, have always been, in a manner

of speaking, 'intangible' (starting from the wax cylinder to modern Blu-ray discs). But books have been firmly grounded in ink and paper, very tangible, with no need for an intermediate object or device to make the content accessible. Moreover, there have been quite accurate processes for automatic conversion of music/video to digital format, but sadly the same is not true for books (OCR software does not even exist for some of the major languages/scripts of the world).

Various efforts are being made to transform the old content into new, and some of them (Project Gutenberg's distributed proof-reading project, etc) are quite promising. The volume of pre-existing content (which cannot be reliably transformed automatically) calls for a distributed, truly worldwide effort. I have heard of a recent demo in which an application opened a book from the Internet Archive, let the reader fix errors, and then re-uploaded the changes back again. I think at some point, it may make sense to add this functionality to the reader devices and software as well. 

Attribution:

- Sayamindu Dasgupta's image on the first page is copyrighted by Kushal Das. The image is released under Creative Commons Attribution-Share Alike 2.0 Generic Licence.
- The eBookReader screenshot is taken from http://sayamindu.randomink.org/profile/images/read_notes.png

By: Sankarshan Mukhopadhyay

The author has been using Fedora since the days of Fedora Core 1. He can be reached at sankarshan@fedoraproject dot org, or as sankarshan@jabber.com on IM.